Foreign Policy: Shield of the Republic (1943), foreign commitments must be brought into balance with national power.[19] Writing, like Spykman, during the dark days of World War II, he asserted that a strategic imbalance was a direct cause of war. He scathingly faulted US foreign policy in the Pacific from 1899 to 1942 for failing to recognize the imbalance between US commitments and its power in relation to the rise of Japan, which America was unable to deter and unprepared to stop. Since 1945, however, except for a limited challenge by the Soviet Union, America has not had a credible challenger in the Pacific. Not since Vietnam nearly a half century ago—which was the last time it brought localized power to bear on the Asiatic rimland—has Washington had to ensure that its Asian commitments and its power were in balance.

Unlike when Huntington was writing what might be considered the urtext of offshore balancing, America now faces in China a credible challenger for local control. Beijing has identified control of the Asiatic Mediterranean as its goal and is acting to permanently change the geopolitical balance by deploying low-tech weapons swarms alongside high-tech weaponry, and through such initiatives as the island-building campaign. Washington thus risks failing to meet this challenge in two respects: not ensuring that its commitments and its power in the region are in balance and not appropriately recognizing the full scope of the challenge and its holistic nature. Any moves toward an offshore balancing posture as a way to reduce potential friction with China will further weaken America's ability to maintain stability and bring to bear military power when and where necessary.

The recent concern in Washington over China's capabilities and intentions is a belated recognition of these facts. Policy makers are now increasingly worried that American power is not commensurate with US commitments, especially if the commitment is understood as the continued stability of the marginal seas and ensuring that no one power controls them. From that perspective, Washington's alliance structures ironically may be secondary to the primacy of control of the marginal